

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 1

Coffee

"The Morning Ritual"

English Language Arts

Teacher Curriculum Packet

High School Pilot | 2026-2027

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for the core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You don't need to play the full episode. CUT-1D is the Economics segment; CUT-1E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These four patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC, covering 21 episodes. Each subject connects to the patterns most relevant to that discipline:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how it tastes.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.

- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 1 Overview: Coffee

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Morning Ritual
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-1A	Cold Open: A Cup of	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-1B	The Bean Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-1C	From Ethiopia to Empire	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-1D	What's in Your Cup?	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-1E	Stories in Every Cup	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-1F	The Conscious Cup (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 1 follows coffee from the volcanic highlands of Ethiopia through the colonial trade routes that spread it globally, to the supply chain economics that determine who earns what from the world's second-largest commodity market. Anthony McDonald opens with his morning routine in Indianapolis and traces the cup in his hand back through geography, history, economics, and literature.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. The Season 2 finale (Episode 14) includes a cross-subject Pattern Wall activity that explicitly connects all four disciplines.

ELA Vocabulary and Rhetorical Framework

Introduce these terms before playing the ELA segment (CUT-1E, starting at 26:00).

Term	Definition	Example in Episode 1
Ethos	Rhetorical appeal to credibility or authority.	Pasqua Rosee's 1652 ad claims medical authority to make coffee seem respectable to skeptical English consumers.
Pathos	Rhetorical appeal to emotion.	Coffee advertising uses imagery of warmth, morning routines, and family connection.
Logos	Rhetorical appeal to logic and evidence.	BVC uses peer-reviewed citations to build its analytical claims throughout the episode.
Narrative nonfiction	Factual content presented using storytelling techniques such as character, setting, and tension.	Anthony McDonald uses his personal morning routine as an entry point into global commodity analysis.

Primary source	An original document, artifact, or testimony from the time period being studied.	Pasqua Rosee's 1652 advertisement; Francis Bacon's 1627 account; Dutch East India Company records.
Secondary source	Analysis or interpretation of primary sources, written after the fact.	Peer-reviewed articles about coffee history; economic analyses of the supply chain.
Framing	The choice of which aspects of an issue to emphasize, which to omit, and what assumptions to embed in the presentation.	How coffee brand marketing frames farmers vs. how investigative journalism frames them.
Cultural appropriation	Using elements of a marginalized culture's practice for commercial benefit without consent or acknowledgment.	The Ethiopian Buna ceremony informing Starbucks origin-story marketing while Ethiopian farmers earn \$2 to \$3 per
Supply chain narrative	The story told about where a product comes from, including what is highlighted and what is made invisible.	Coffee brands show scenic origin farms. They do not show daily wages.
Rhetorical analysis	Systematic examination of how language is used to persuade, including which strategies are used and why they work.	The core skill applied to all three primary source documents in this packet.

Primary Source Collection: Coffee in Historical Texts

Document 1: Pasqua Rosee's Coffee Advertisement (London, 1652)

The Vertue of the COFFEE Drink. First publiquely made and sold in England, by Pasqua Rosee...

"It will prevent drowsiness and make one fit for business. It is excellent to prevent and cure the dropsy, gout and scurvy, as well as scrofula, miscarriages and a most excellent remedy against the spleen, hypocondriack winds and the like."

-- Printed handbill, London, 1652

Context: Rosee was a Greek immigrant from Istanbul who opened London's first coffeehouse. He needed to convince a skeptical English public to try a drink associated with Ottoman Turkish culture.

Document 2: Francis Bacon on Coffee (1627)

"They have in Turkey a drink called coffa made of a berry of the same name, as black as soot, and of a strong scent... this drink comforteth the brain and heart, and helpeth digestion."

-- Francis Bacon, *Sylva Sylvarum*, 1627

Context: Francis Bacon was England's Lord Chancellor and one of its leading intellectual figures. His endorsement gave coffee considerable credibility among educated Europeans.

Document 3: Charles II's Proclamation Against Coffeehouses (1675)

"His Majesty doth hereby Prohibit all persons from keeping any Coffee House... Coffee houses have produced very evil and dangerous effects; as well for that many tradesmen and others do therein misspend much of their time, which might and probably would otherwise be employed in and about their lawful calling and affairs."

-- Royal Proclamation, 1675 (withdrawn 11 days later after merchant protest)

Context: Charles II was alarmed that coffeehouses enabled political dissent, pamphlet-reading, and organized opposition to his government. The language of misspent time conceals this.

Document 4: The Supply Chain Gap (for the Step 3 Activity)

Text A (brand marketing):

"Our single-origin Ethiopian coffee is hand-selected from small farms in the Yirgacheffe highlands. Each cup connects you to the farmers who grew it with generations of expertise."

Text B (documented supply chain data):

Ethiopian farmers in the Yirgacheffe region earn approximately \$2 to \$3 per day growing coffee that retails for \$4 to \$5 per cup in the United States. The farmer's entire daily wage is represented in roughly the first two minutes of a cafe's operating day.

Both texts are factually accurate. The rhetorical difference is what each one chooses to emphasize.

ELA Activity: Reading the Label

Time: 40 to 45 minutes. Materials: this packet. Optional: a physical coffee bag or photograph of one.

Step 1: Primary Source Close Reading (15 minutes)

Students read Documents 1, 2, and 3. For each document, they complete a quick-write:

- Who is speaking? What is their relationship to coffee?
- What rhetorical appeal is being used: ethos, pathos, or logos?
- What does the document want the reader to do, believe, or feel?
- What does the document not mention? What is absent from its framing of coffee?

Step 2: The Charles II Paradox (10 minutes)

Charles II's proclamation frames political suppression as concern about worker productivity.

- Why was using misspent time language strategically smarter than saying coffeehouses threaten my government?
- Identify a contemporary example where you think the stated reason for a policy differs from the actual reason. (Students do not need to name a specific policy. The goal is recognizing the rhetorical pattern.)

Step 3: The Supply Chain Narrative Gap (10 minutes)

Compare Texts A and B from Document 4:

- Both texts are factually accurate. What does Text A include? What does it omit?
- What does connects you to the farmers mean in Text A? What would genuine economic connection actually require?
- Identify the rhetorical appeals in Text A. Are any present in Text B? Why or why not?

Step 4: Writing (10 minutes)

Students write 150 to 200 words responding to one of these prompts:

- Option A: Rewrite Text A's marketing paragraph to be both honest and still compelling. What do you keep? What do you add? Can marketing be accurate and appealing at the same time?
- Option B: Write the 100-word version of Text B that you think should appear on the coffee bag alongside the brand's narrative. What does the consumer have a right to know?

ELA Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. Identify the primary rhetorical appeal in Pasqua Rosee's 1652 advertisement and explain how it works. Why would this appeal have been effective for Rosee's specific audience and purpose?

2. Charles II's 1675 proclamation frames political suppression as concern about worker productivity. Identify this rhetorical technique by name and explain why using the language of work and productivity was strategically smarter than naming the actual political threat.

3. Texts A and B in Document 4 describe the same economic reality from different vantage points. In three to four sentences, explain what rhetorical choice Text A makes and what the reader cannot understand about the supply chain after reading Text A alone.

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Rosee uses ethos, an appeal to authority, by claiming coffee cures gout, scurvy, and other ailments. This was effective because his audience was skeptical of an unfamiliar Ottoman drink, and medical claims were credible in 17th century England even without modern scientific standards. Framing coffee as medicine also connected it to professional respectability rather than foreign novelty. Students must name the appeal and explain both its mechanism and its audience-specific effectiveness.

Q2 expected answer:

The technique is strategic reframing: framing a political action as a social or economic concern. Using misspent time makes the suppression sound neutral and managerial, not political. This is strategically smarter because naming political opposition would legitimize it and make the king appear threatened. Productivity language appeals to merchants' economic self-interest rather than politicizing them. Students should connect this to contemporary examples of the same rhetorical pattern.

Q3 expected answer:

Text A centers the emotional and experiential connection between consumer and origin: warmth, expertise, hand-selection. What the reader cannot understand after reading Text A alone is the actual economic relationship between them. The magnitude of the wage gap, the farmer's inability to share in the premium the brand commands, and the difference between connection as a marketing claim versus connection as economic equity are all invisible in Text A. Strong answers note that hand-selected and generations of expertise construct a warm relationship that would feel violated if the reader encountered the wage data from Text B.

Indiana ELA Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
11-12.RI.2.1	Cite strong textual evidence to support analysis of explicit and inferential meaning	Primary source analysis questions require specific textual evidence from the documents
11-12.RI.3.1	Analyze how an author's choices shape meaning and style	Rosee's medical framing; Charles II's productivity framing; Text A vs. Text B comparison
11-12.W.3.2	Write informative/explanatory texts to examine complex ideas clearly and accurately	Step 4 writing options A and B
11-12.W.4.1	Write arguments to support claims using valid reasoning and relevant evidence	Knowledge check Q3 requires a three-to-four sentence evidence-based
11-12.SL.2.1	Initiate and participate in collaborative discussions with diverse partners	Charles II paradox discussion; supply chain narrative comparison activity
11-12.L.3.1	Apply understanding of syntax and rhetoric to reading and writing	Ethos, pathos, logos framework applied across all three primary source documents

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or helpful?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next fall:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?